perform other regions and states," says A.V. Monish Row, managing partner of AVBGPR & Co., the first shipping company of Visakhapatnam.

Core strengths—being a prominent seaport—have contributed to Vizag's steady growth. It is the leading exporter of seafood and cultured shrimp in the country. "Over the decades, all major seafood exporters are here. Iron ore and other minerals are also exported. Now, GIS has amplified the potential in drawing fresh investment," says N.V. Rama Raju, managing director, North East Infrastructure Ltd.

Vizag is indeed a growing marketplace. "The city also serves as a retail hub for gold and silver jewellery and textiles for north Andhra and Odisha," says Mallikharjuna Rao Kankatala, vice president of the Federation of Andhra Pradesh Chambers of Commerce and Industry. The presence of a modern health city at Arilovaa, with over 25 hospitals spread over 70 acres, has led to medical tourism. "Visakhapatnam boasts of high-end healthcare infrastructure comparable to anywhere in India," says Y. Subramaniam, regional CEO, Apollo Hospitals.

Vizag also has a booming real estate market where property prices have doubled in the last four years. The skyline has changed with the new multi-storeyed office and housing blocks. "Ours is the largest city of Andhra Pradesh, and a GDP of over $43.5 billion has positioned it as the ninth richest city in India," says O. Naresh Kumar, vice president, Vizag Development Council, and CEO, Symbiosys Technologies. The hope is Vizag will be to Andhra what Hyderabad is to Telangana. However, that ambition is fraught with numerous challenges.

URBAN CHALLENGES

Rapid urban growth is not easy to handle. A phalanx of issues confronts planners—protecting forest cover and greenery, controlling pollution, mitigating cyclone effects, curbing land-grabbing, creating industrial disaster protection systems, checking unplanned urbanisation and, the biggest of them all, meeting future water needs. The fast-growing city is bursting at its seams already with low-income households who constitute the majority, unable to access affordable housing.

"With a vast complex of industrial clusters all around, the city is becoming polluted. With the VMRDA unable to plan for migrant workers, most of them are forced to live in slums in very poor conditions. Even after the Polavaram project (a multipurpose irrigation and reservoir project) gets implemented, which is uncertain, there is a widening gap between water availability and demand, which could soon snowball into severe water shortage," warns E.A.S. Sarma, former secretary in the central energy and finance ministries. The limited groundwater sources are overexploited and polluted, he says. One of the biggest problems Vizag is likely to face soon is the disposal of urban waste, which calls for out-of-the-box solutions, adds Sarma.



"Visakhapatnam... has the approval of all the people in the state. As part of decentralisation of administration, your son (Reddy) will set up his family also in Visakhapatnam"

Y.S. JAGAN MOHAN REDDY
Chief Minister, Andhra Pradesh

Housing problems, too, are set to become acute. "We should develop more integrated townships with all infrastructure facilities in the suburbs of the core city. To develop a large world-class city, the only alternative is land pooling. For this, the government must find a practical and cost-effective system," says Jasti Balaji, managing partner, Balaji Constructions, a developer in the city since 1987.

Rampant industrialisation will also need necessary safeguards. The public sector has been the driving force for Vizag's growth so far. "It's important to sustain it, while making efforts to bring in private investment," says Ravi Komarraju, security studies specialist and political commentator. "The most crucial parameter in any privatisation move of the public sector is the security dimension. This being the Eastern Naval headquarters and the navy's biggest submarine base, a casual attitude towards privatisation is fraught with serious risks. A private port itself poses a security risk. Privatisation of a vast sea hinterland industry would be foolish in terms of security considerations." The Union government is actively considering divestment in the shore-based Visakhapatnam Steel Plant.

Some veteran Vizagites, as residents refer to themselves, are sceptical about the city evolving as the executive capital. Centre for Policy Studies head and Test cricket commentator A. Prasanna Kumar, who came to enrol himself as a student at the Andhra University 69 years ago, says, "The murky waters of Vijayawada (part of the Andhra Pradesh Capital Region) will flow into Vizag, robbing the City of Destiny of its serenity." But, as Andhra Pradesh High Court Justice D.V.S.S. Somayajulu, the son of a former Vizag mayor, put it succinctly, "In less than a 100 years, it grew from a sleepy fishing village to a bustling town and now in less than a third of that time, Vizag will transform into a mega financial and industrial hub of East India." Why wouldn't a city aspire to that? ■